



The Sharp-End 900

A sharpie for the 21st century

by Jan Briek

Photographs by Bertel Kolthof

To find the roots of the Sharp-End 900 design built for Frans van der Horst of The Netherlands, you have to go back a century and a half and all the way across the Atlantic—to Florida, where a boat called EGRET first saw the light of day.

Frans first became aware of the boat type known as a “sharpie” when he saw *The Sharpie Book* by Reuel B. Parker, a standard work about the type. For Frans, this was the beginning of a new love affair, one that would become more intense as time went by. Thanks to Parker’s book, Frans became acquainted with EGRET, a boat of almost mythical status for sharpie lovers, thanks in no small measure to the writings of her colorful designer and owner, Commodore Ralph Munroe. So in order to really get to know Frans’s Sharp-End, we have to go back 150 years in time.

To be more precise, we have to go to southern Florida in the second half of the 19th century. After the end of the Civil War, settlers from the north gradually

began to develop this area, bringing their boats with them. Some of these boats proved perfectly suited to the waterways there, which are shallow, relatively sheltered, often dried-out, and with thousands of bays, creeks, and islands. Ralph Munroe was one of those most responsible for the introduction of these boats, particularly a type called a New Haven sharpie, which originated among Connecticut oystermen. When Munroe moved from Staten Island, New York, to southern Florida, he had the first such boat shipped to him on the deck of a steamboat. The sharpie took to the South like a fish to water, partly because of its shallow draft (often 12” or less with the centerboard raised) but especially because of its no-nonsense character. With their hard-chined hulls, the boats were extremely easy to build. A good boatbuilder could finish a 30-footer in just six days for only \$200.

Munroe went on to import a number of sharpies from the North, but in 1886 he decided to devise his

Above—Inspired by Commodore Ralph Munroe’s EGRET of 1886, the Sharp-End 900 retains many original characteristics, but unlike the sharpies of oystermen, she’s fitted out in yacht style.

own adaptation, and thus EGRET was born. By then, Munroe had become the postmaster for a 70-mile-long coastal area, and he needed a shallow but relatively seaworthy boat to deliver the mail.

Colorful Anecdotes

EGRET's fame and reputation grew to almost mythical proportions as time passed, aided by colorful anecdotes reported in Munroe's own 1930 autobiography, *The Commodore's Story*, which he wrote with editorial assistance from his friend Vincent Gilpin. The boat's undisputed seaworthy character as described in these stories inspired subsequent generations of sailors and boat designers to create their own versions of EGRET.

"She would run under whole sail in anything," Munroe wrote of his EGRET, "and swooped down the lake like the arrow from a bow...and ended the performance with a sensational jibe and round-up, possible only to her light and nimble type rig, which turns and stops like a polo pony."

Later, Gilpin's role in this story became much more important. As the years went by, both Munroe and EGRET fell prey to time, as all things do. But in 1926, almost all of Munroe's drawings—including those of EGRET—were lost in a tropical storm. Munroe's followers had to resort to his written descriptions and photographs to reconstruct his design. Nothing else remained—or at least, that's what everyone thought. One of Munroe's followers was Bill Schwicker (see WB No. 77), who also sailed the thin waters of the Southern coast and who wanted to build a sharpie like EGRET. His

research proved fruitless, until a Northern friend, more specifically a New Englander, handed him a drawing inscribed with the legend "R.M. Munroe, Sharpie 29'." The drawing was from Gilpin's archive. This discovery in turn inspired Schwicker to visit Munroe's grandson, Bill Munroe, in Miami. Bill Munroe, who was also a yacht designer, had found an antique half model in his grandfather's estate and, as you can guess, one plus one equaled two. The two pieces of the puzzle needed to reconstruct EGRET had been found. EGRET's design was finally put on paper, commissioned by WoodenBoat and aided by Jon Wilson, Maynard Bray, Joel White, and David Dillion. Schwicker, although initially inspired by EGRET, built a sharpie that differed in some respects. And his EGRET was given a place of prominence in *The Sharpie Book*.

A Boat That Wasn't There

And now we've come full circle back to Frans's sharpie: the Sharp-End 900. "I was looking for a boat that really didn't exist," Frans said, "a camp-cruiser with shallow draft but with enough comfort and enough storage space, for example, for two mountain bikes. When I saw EGRET, I was very attracted by the idea. EGRET had been a great success in her day, particularly because she was such a good transport boat. The changes Munroe made to the original sharpie design—EGRET was a double-ender and had a bit more freeboard—had proven successful."

However, Frans decided to do more than just order the drawings from WoodenBoat and have the boat built.

The shoal-water abilities that made sharpies effective in the thin waters of Florida also made the type highly desirable for Frans van der Horst's shallow cruising grounds in The Netherlands.

Sharp-End 900 Particulars

LOA	9m (29'6")
Beam	2.45m (8')
Draft (board up)	.3m (12")
Draft (board down)	1.50m (4'11")
Displacement	2,100kg (4,630 lbs)
Ballast	300kg (661 lbs)
Sail area	29m ² (312 sq ft)
Engine	7-hp Bukh, 1-cylinder





A ballasted daggerboard not only prevents leeway but also provides stability.

He wanted to be inspired by tradition but not bound by it. So off he went to yacht designer Martin de Jager with a list of additions and changes. "It was a wonderful job," de Jager says now. "You don't often encounter someone who's so involved in a project and who's so in love with a certain type of boat. Frans had done an enormous amount of research and had collected a lot of information, which he gave to us."

When designing the Sharp-End, de Jager used EGRET as a starting point, but he made adjustments to the hull, some of which were influenced by making the boat certified for inshore navigation under European Union rules (see sidebar, page 64). "The Sharp-End is almost half a meter [1'7½"] longer than the original, and we based its beam on the maximum legal trailer width, 2.5 meters (about 8'). After having analyzed the form of the original hull, we decided that it would be better to expand the width at the waterline by making the contours of the hull more vertical. That improves the stability without damaging the sailing characteristics." Martin is full of praise for the almost natural balance of the sharpie hull: "The boat remains in perfect balance at any angle of heel, it has a good, sharp waterline at the bow, and its stern rises nicely out of the water."

Another important change can be found underwater. The original EGRET had a centerboard, and she also had inside ballast that could be removed when she was carrying cargo. A more contemporary solution was

chosen for the Sharp-End: a retractable ballast keel combined with a rudder blade that can be raised in a small well in the afterdeck (see sidebar, page 63). Sharpies sail very well to windward because of the position of the rudder and board, de Jager said. With a keel and rudder that can both be raised, the boat can sail in very shallow water, and the ballast in her keel increases her stability when the keel is lowered.

But the changes to the hull were not the only alterations. Frans also wanted a self-draining cockpit and slightly higher freeboard to provide more accommodation belowdecks. But the word "more" is out of place here, since the original EGRET had no accommodations at all. That boat was used to transport mail and supplies, not cruise with guests. Munroe could only take shelter under a cuddy at the forward end of the cockpit. "But a little bit of comfort was essential," Frans said. "It was going to be a camping boat, but one on which two people could camp in luxury." If more than two people are aboard, a tent can be set up over the cockpit so there are two more places to sleep.

With EGRET as its forerunner, this modern sharpie is based on tradition but fully prepared for the 21st century.



With comfortable accommodations and a well-fitted-out galley, the double-ender allows camp-cruising in style.



Wishbone booms fitted with topping lifts on both masts allow the sails to be doused quickly and easily, captured by lines slung below the booms. Webbing (inset) keeps the boom in the right position on the mast.

Unstayed Masts

Whatever can be said about the Sharp-End in general applies even more to the rigging: it is based on tradition but with modern construction. Originally, sharpies had one or two unstayed masts that could easily be unshipped. She used traditional workboat-style sprit-booms, as well, but to achieve better sail shape, Frans elected to use wishbone booms (*spreigieken* in archaic nautical Dutch) on the Sharp-End. These booms have another advantage: when struck, the sail and gaff store easily in lines slung under the wishbone. Her masts and gaffs are made of carbon fiber to save weight, something you appreciate when lowering and raising the masts. Keeping the rig lightweight also benefits her stability.

A Pearl Made of Wood

The Sharp-End built by Benno Rexwinkel and his team at Rexwinkel Shipyards in the port of Dordrecht is an absolute pearl made of wood with countless custom-made details that make her something special. And if this means that one of the essential characteristics of the sharpie—simplicity—has faded into the background? So be it! Frans wanted to make his Sharp-End a beautiful boat, which is something you can entrust this shipyard to do. Moreover, the level of comfort on



The rudder retracts daggerboard-style from its housing, with five different settings for a through-pin. The pintles are fixed to a post that rotates in fittings attached to the forward face of a well that passes through the hull.

The Rudder: Simple but Effective

The Sharp-End 900's rudder functions like a transom-mounted one. It is supported by two fittings bolted onto a narrow bulkhead, which acts like a false transom and is just above the waterline, according to designer Martin de Jager. This bulkhead forms the forward end of a rudder well that extends through the hull and the deck. The rudder blade slides up and down through two aluminum pintles that are bolted to a vertical post. This assembly rotates in the bulkhead fittings, which both are equipped with high-density nylon bearings. The rudder's height is set by an athwartship pin that runs through a hole in the blade and rests on top of the upper aluminum bracket. "I must admit that I was afraid that the rudder would cause a lot of turbulence and great fountains of water at higher speeds," de Jager says, "but it doesn't happen. The opening in the bottom always stays just above the water."

—JB

Designing with EU rules in mind

The Sharp-End is a new design based on a traditional boat," designer Martin de Jager says. "As such, it's not required to comply with the European Union's Recreation Craft Directive (RCD). The various traditional types of boats in Europe were given an exemption, since they would otherwise not be built any more if their design would prohibit them from being compliant."

However, because the owner hopes to market other boats built to this design, he chose to comply with the regulations, de Jager said. The RCD regulates recreational boats between 2.4m and 24m long (7'10" and 78'8"). The regulations give minimum requirements for equipment, strength, and stability. The boat, which is designed for use in the shallow waters of the Dutch coast, will be certified under rules for inland waters.

"The stability requirements have had the most influence on the design," de Jager said. The original EGRET had only internal ballast, but by using external ballast in the centerboard, de Jager was able to design the hull to be self-righting. Also, the cockpit is self-draining, meeting another RCD requirement. "The watertightness of hatches, etc., has to comply with the regulations to make sure that the boat will withstand certain angles of heel without flooding. Other requirements do not have a specific influence on the design, as they are either common sense—such as strength—or have more to do with equipment." —JB

board the Sharp-End is much higher than on the traditional sharpies. Of course, this boat wasn't built in a week or at a cost of \$200, as in the old days in Florida. Rexwinkel spent about seven months on the construction. "But part of that time was spent on figuring out the various constructions," Benno said. "Everything had been thought of, but then we had to make it. We spent a lot of time puzzling over the construction of the keel, the mechanism used to move the keel up and down, the rudder construction in the compartment, and the rigging."

The Sharp-End is built of marine plywood, 20mm thick on the bottom and, to save weight, 12mm on the topsides. All of the bulkheads are also of marine plywood. Structural members such as her keelson, sternpost, and horn timber are made of massive mahogany.

A cockpit compartment accommodates ample gear storage—including a folding bicycle that extends the pleasures of camp-cruising.

That same material was used for the interior and exterior trim. The cabin sole is of Alaska yellow cedar bounded by mahogany. The cockpit is finished in teak.

Another departure from the past is the use of an inboard engine: a 7-hp Bukh one-cylinder diesel, the smallest engine possible, weighing just under 176 lbs (80 kilos). The folding propeller is behind a skeg, so it's well protected if the boat dries out. And the motor isn't the only bit of luxury onboard. There's also a double-burner alcohol stove, a washbasin, a 32-gallon water tank, refrigeration, heat, a dry toilet, and a pair of batteries for starting and lighting—it's all there. In that respect, the Sharp-End is just as comfortable as a conventional 30-footer. But the construction is completely different....

A Wonderful Boat

After sailing aboard SHARP-END twice, Bertil and I found that you just can't deny that the joint efforts of Frans van der Horst, Martin de Jager, and Benno Rexwinkel have resulted in a wonderful and saucy boat that also sails very well. Setting both sails is a piece of cake, as is storing them, thanks to the two wishbones. And this boat sails like the best of them. At about Beaufort 3—a gentle breeze of 7 to 10 knots—SHARP-END handily points upwind within a 40-degree angle and it continues to sail at speed, easily reaching 5.5 knots. By pointing a little lower, she does a half knot to a full knot more. While we were sailing on the Hollands Diep, many bigger keelboats had to do their very best to pass us—if they were able to at all. And when the light wind





With her two unstayed carbon-fiber masts and simple rigging, the Sharp-End 900 promises not only a good turn of speed but also easy handling.

becomes a bit gusty, the Sharp-End 900 is really in her element, quickly picking up speed and continuing to sail without faltering.

And as for handling—it's child's play. The skipper can sail the boat alone because the rig is largely self-tending. If you want to tack, all you have to do is change course. If you want to steer a bit lower to the wind, you only have to ease the sheets. That's all. Frans has become so convinced of his boat's concept that he can see a market for it in The Netherlands. What has always been true about the waterways around Florida is also true of many of our Dutch waterways. Of course, it's much warmer over there....

It would be great if we soon saw more of these evolved

EGRETS sailing in The Netherlands. Even Commodore Munroe himself could never have imagined that. 

Jan Briek is senior editor with the Dutch maritime magazine Waterkampioen, where this article originally appeared.

• Frans van der Horst, +31-6-311-95-311;
www.whitewatersharpie.nl.

• Rexwinkel Jachtbouw, Papeterspad 20-23, 3311 WT Dordrecht, The Netherlands, +31-78-613-17-22;
www.rexwinkeljachtbouw.nl.

• Martin de Jager Yacht Design, Schiedamseweg 57, 3121 JE Schiedam, The Netherlands, +31-10-470-48-62
www.jensdesign.nl.